



review

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It's hard to fit *Wheelman* into a particular genre. There is so much variation in the game that the only safe category it would fall under is 'action', and there is tons of that on offer here.

And you shouldn't expect any different with Vin Diesel playing the game's protagonist, Milo. Developed by Diesel's own Tigon Studio, the actor has been closely involved in the development of *Wheelman*, and considering the fact that the last game he was associated with was the cult favourite *Chronicles of Riddick: Escape from Butcher Bay*, expectations from *Wheelman* are quite high.

But while *Wheelman* meets expectations in certain aspects, it falls short on others. The game feels like an assorted platter of gameplay elements from various other games — *Driver*, *Pursuit Force*, *Burnout*, *Need for Speed*, *Grand Theft Auto*, and *Test Drive*, just to name a few — and it ultimately fails to create an identity of its own. Milo, played by Diesel, is a CIA agent stationed in Barcelona, Spain, and is tasked with infiltrating the underworld, comprised of three large gangs.

All of Barcelona is your playground in this mission-based, free-roaming game, where you are required to complete various

Score - 3/5

Developer: Tigon

Publisher: Midway

Genre: Driving-Action

Release Date: March 27

Platforms: Xbox 360, PS3

WHEELMAN™



tasks for these three gangs. While most of the game involves driving, there are also missions that require gunplay, but these are extremely basic and only seem to be thrown into the mix to add a little variety. The auto-aim system, dull enemy AI, and cement blocks conveniently placed for cover make the gun combat segments a breeze, and you'll find yourself hoping to get back behind the wheel.

The driving missions on the other hand are quite engaging and varied. They include taking out other cars *Burnout*-style, air-jacking cars, chasing someone down on a two-wheeler through narrow alleys, and even stealth driving to avoid police detection. Air-jacking is possibly the coolest addition to the game, albeit lifted straight from *Pursuit Force* on the PSP. It basically lets you leap from your moving vehicle to another vehicle in front of you, thereby letting you carjack it while still in motion.

The driving mechanic is extremely arcadey and is designed to be easily accessible to those new to driving games. To make things even easier, you can perform melee attacks with your car. It's similar to how you would side-swipe a car in *Burnout* to earn a takedown, only that rather than having to come in with speed and momentum, all you need to do is push your right stick in the direction of your target, and your vehicle will violently propel itself in that sideways direction. It's not the most realistic addition to a driving game, but realism isn't something that the developers seemed to be aiming for either.

The game employs a focus-meter, which fills up when you drive fast, perform handbrake turns, or drive without crashing. Filling the meter up gives you a nitro boost. When the meter is completely full, you also have two style maneuvers added to your arsenal — the aimed shot and the cyclone. The aimed shot allows you to slow time down, similar to reaction time in *Need for Speed* games, and you can use your gun to pick off enemies that may be in your way. The cyclone is similar, but this is used when the enemy you want to take out is behind you. Activating cyclone will slow time down and

perform a 180-degree turn and allow you to shoot at your enemy before turning back around. Since most of the missions involve hostiles in vehicles, these attacks are vital to your success.

Besides the game's main missions, you also have a variety of optional side-missions, and this is where the game impresses with its depth. These side missions include *Midnight Club*-like checkpoint races, Taxi missions inspired by *Test Drive Unlimited*, rampage, a mode similar to *Cost to the State* from recent *Need for Speed* games, time trials, and more. The side missions, while not very original, are plenty and depending on how well you perform, you will be awarded a grade. Achieving the A grade in a side mission gives you added perks such as strengthening your vehicle, making it less vulnerable to hostile drivers, extra boost, etc.

While the story as well as the main and side missions are good, the game is ultimately undone by its inconsistent driving mechanics. There aren't too many vehicles in the game, yet the same vehicle will handle differently around every corner. The broken controls are best demonstrated in the Vespa chase mission, where pushing the left stick slightly will result in a sharp 90-degree turn. Maybe this was done to show the Vespa's limited turning radius, but you can't spring this on the player when the rest of the game is so blatantly arcade. In terms of presentation as well, *Wheelman* is left wanting. Dodgy frame rates make the game virtually unplayable at times (we played the PS3 version). Even when the frame rates do hold steady, the game is visually below average and something you wouldn't even expect from a console launch title.

Wheelman has some good ideas. Many of the missions are fun, the side missions and perks system add a lot of depth to the game, there are some cool driving maneuvers that you can perform, and even the story and voice acting is serviceable. But all of that is nullified by the clearly broken driving mechanic, which forms the core of the game. It isn't bad by any means, but coupled with the choppy visuals, it falls way short of the mark and ends up as a game that is hard to recommend. ■

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